The duo brings together their separate experiences with OTT scores and club music in this new work

Punditz record are Shruti Pathak, with whom Raina has performed at concerts by Karsh Kale and who renders the ghazal 'Dafatan'. There is also Shubha Mudgal, whom they got on board for the evocative kajri 'Sakhi'. The lilting 'Rangeeli' features Indian Ocean's Rahul Ram on bass. Percussionist Vineet Singh aka Bang It Paaji, whom they enlisted for the experimental instrumental 'Encrypted', gelled so well with the duo that he's now a part of their live ensemble.

They're all tracks that will fit seamlessly into their set list when they take the album on tour towards the end of the year. Fortunately for fans, they've continued to perform relatively frequently. Most recently, they played festivals such as Motoverse in Goa and SulaFest in Nashik. Such gigs serve as heartening reminders of the strong bond the pair share. "We may not talk to each other for a week," says Raina. "But we always come back and remember that we're friends before we're business partners. That's important [because] you need something that keeps the foundation intact. So, when there's a problem, it gets handled." ■

—Amit Gurbaxani

PLAYING BALL

No, India is not among the 48 teams competing in the 2026 FIFA WORLD CUP. However, there will be four players of Indian origin competing in the world's most watched sporting event

↘ SAMUEL MOUTOUSSAMMY *(DR Congo)*

Born in Paris, Samuel represents Republic of the Congo, where his mother is from, while his father is an Indo-Guadeloupean of Tamil origin. The defensive midfielder was part of FC Nantes from France's Ligue 1 for seven years and currently plays for the Greek club Atromitos F.C. Congo have their work cut out in Group K where they face Portugal, Colombia and Uzbekistan.

↘ NISHAN VELUPILLAY *(Australia)*

In Nishan's debut for the Socceroos, the winger scored against China in the World Cup qualifiers in October 2024. That game and one against Indonesia, and his run with the Melbourne Victory club, were enough for the 25-year-old to make the squad. Nishan's father, Sasinath, is Malaysian of Sri Lankan Tamil heritage while mother Gillian is Anglo-Indian. Nishan's ability to attack and score when called for may work for him.

↘ TAHSIN MOHAMMED JAMSHID *(Qatar)*

Only 19, Tahsin inherits his passion for football from his father, Jamshid Thachakandhy, whose career in the sport in Kerala was cut short due to injury. Like his idol Cristiano Ronaldo, Tahsin is a forward, albeit one who can play on the left and right wing. The youngest in the nation's WC team, Tahsin will hope to get some minutes against Switzerland, Canada and Bosnia and Herzegovina.

↘ SARPREET SINGH *(New Zealand)*

Punjab, too, will have someone to root for this World Cup. Auckland-born Sarpreet was the first player of Indian descent to join Bundesliga giants FC Bayern Munich. But it has been with New Zealand's A League team Wellington Phoenix (where he currently plays) that the midfielder made a big impression and ultimately earned a place on the NZ team, the All Whites.

—Suhani Singh



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